

The Doctrine of Baptisms

Hebrews 6:1–2 | Foundations

Hebrews lists baptisms — plural — as a foundation, not a footnote. The writer is not pointing only to the single act of water baptism familiar to us, but to a whole doctrine of washings and identifications that run through the whole of Scripture: the cleansing rites of the Old Covenant, John's baptism of repentance, and the baptism into Christ's death and resurrection that Paul describes in Romans 6.

To lay this foundation properly, a believer must be able to distinguish these baptisms from one another, and see how each one prepared the way for the next.

The Washings of the Old Covenant

Long before John stood in the Jordan, Israel already possessed a doctrine of washings. The Levitical priesthood was consecrated through washing (Exodus 29:4). The laver stood between the altar and the tabernacle, so that no priest could approach the presence of God without first being cleansed (Exodus 30:17–21). These were not empty rituals; they taught Israel, in physical form, a truth their hearts needed long before they could receive it in full: that no one enters the presence of a holy God carrying the defilement of ordinary life.

The writer of Hebrews later calls these washings a shadow of “good things to come” (Hebrews 10:1) — not the substance itself, but a pattern pointing forward to something the blood of bulls and goats could never actually accomplish: a conscience made truly clean.

John's Baptism of Repentance

John's baptism marked a turn. It was not merely ceremonial washing repeated for ritual purity, but a baptism “of repentance for the remission of sins” (Mark 1:4) — a public, once-for-all act declaring that a person had turned from the old direction of their life toward God. Crowds came from Jerusalem and all Judea, confessing their sins as they were baptized (Matthew 3:5–6).

Yet even John knew his baptism was preparatory, not final. “I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance,” he said, “but He who is coming after me is mightier than I... He will baptize you with

the Holy Spirit and fire” (Matthew 3:11). John's baptism cleared the ground. It could not yet plant what was coming.

Baptized Into His Death

Paul takes the doctrine further still. To be baptized into Christ, he writes, is to be baptized into His death — “buried with Him through baptism into death, that just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life” (Romans 6:3–4). This is no longer only a washing from sin, nor only a mark of repentance. It is an identification: the believer's whole story is now bound up in Christ's story. The old self is not improved; it is put to death and raised new.

Colossians says it plainly: believers were “buried with Him in baptism, in which you also were raised with Him through faith in the working of God, who raised Him from the dead” (Colossians 2:12). Baptism, rightly understood, is never a work that saves. It is the visible declaration of a death and resurrection that has already taken place by faith.

The Weight the Early Church Gave It

The early Church treated baptism with a seriousness we have often lost. In the fourth century, Cyril of Jerusalem prepared candidates for baptism over many weeks, examining their repentance before ever bringing them to the water. Instructing the newly baptized afterward, he told them plainly what had actually happened to them:

“Ye were led down to the holy pool of Divine Baptism... and each of you was asked, whether he believed in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost... and ye made that saving confession, and descended three times into the water, and ascended again... in the self-same moment ye died and were born; and that Water of salvation was at once your grave and your mother.”

— Cyril of Jerusalem, Catechetical Lecture XX

Grave and mother, in the same water, in the same moment. That is the doctrine of baptisms taken to its full weight — not a formality completed once and set aside, but the ongoing shape of a life that has already died with Christ and already been raised with Him.

FOR REFLECTION

Do you relate to your own baptism as a completed event in the past, or as an ongoing identity you are still learning to live from — buried with Christ, and already raised to walk in newness of life?

Where in your life this month does the old self still expect to be consulted, as though it had not already been put to death?

This month we sit with that weight: not baptism as a box to be checked, but as the daily, ongoing reality of a life that has already died with Christ, and now lives identified with Him alone.

Shalom.

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